



The Right Side

A GUIDE TO MEZUZAH PLACEMENT

BY RABBI SHIMON HELLINGER

REVIEWED BY RABBI YOSEF SHUSTERMAN, DAYAN LEVI YITZCHOK RASKIN, RABBI BARUCH HERTZ

Rabbi Menachem Mendel Gluckowsky of Rechovot tells a story about a baal habos from Toronto whose young son was ill with whooping cough for an extended time. He wrote to the Rebbe and received a reply to check his mezuzos. Surprised, the man called up the mazkirus office to say that he had just moved into a new home and had purchased all of his mezuzos from Rabbi Yosef Gansburg, the Rebbe's shliach to Toronto. Rabbi Binyomin Klein inquired as to who had put up the mezuzos. The man replied that he had done so himself. Rabbi Klein told him that sometimes when the Rebbe says to check the mezuzos he is referring to their placement, and recommended that the man ask Rabbi Gansburg to come and make sure all of the mezuzos were indeed affixed in their proper places.

Rabbi Gansburg walked through the house and checked the placement of the mezuzos. When he arrived at the room of the young boy who was ill, he found the mezuzah affixed to the bottom half of the doorframe. The baal habos explained that he wanted his son to be able to kiss the mezuzah but, as he was often away and his wife was expecting and unable to lift the child, he had put the mezuzah in a place where his young son could reach it.

Rabbi Gansburg re-affixed the mezuzah in the correct location and, boruch Hashem, the young boy's health improved.

Most observant Jews today are familiar with the importance of verifying the kashrus of mezuzos. The many details required to make a mezuzah kosher and the many issues that can invalidate it compel the responsible consumer to research

the authenticity of a mezuzah before buying it. Even after establishing a mezuzah's authenticity, many will ensure its ongoing kashrus by checking it regularly. Some people go so far as to check their mezuzos every year, particularly in Elul, in preparation for the new year.² Yet, surprisingly, an essential aspect of the mezuzah's kashrus often does not merit the same level of attention: the mezuzah's placement.

Even with the most mehudar mezuzah, a person only fulfills the mitzvah when it is placed correctly on the doorpost. Halacha goes into great detail describing exactly where on the doorpost a mezuzah must be placed for every possible kind of doorway, and states clearly that if a mezuzah is not placed correctly it is as if the mezuzah wasn't placed at all.³

The problem of misplaced *mezuzos* is not a new one. Rabbi Eliyahu David Rabinowitz-Teomim, the "Aderes," records in one letter, "In most of the homes that I have visited, I found some error in placement of mezuzos."⁴ With the decline in rabbinic home visits and the rise of innovative architecture, the problem has only increased.

As shluchim of the Rebbe, in our capacity as foot soldiers on the front-lines of the Rebbe's mivtzah mezuzah, it is our priority to ensure an increase in rabbinic home visits to guarantee kosher placement of mezuzos in as many Jewish homes as we can.

In this article we will review some of the underlying principles and common errors of kvias mezuzah.

² *Mateh Efrayim*, §581. The Rebbe asked that this worthy custom be publicized. See *Sefer HaSichos* 5748, Vol. 2, p. 610.

³ *Shulchan Aruch*, *Yoreh Deiah*, 289:2.

⁴ *Nefesh Dovid* §16.

What Makes a Doorway a Doorway?

In order to constitute a doorway, it must have at least a right doorpost (even if the left side is flush) and a lintel (though it is not necessary for them to be attached). However, because there are some who require two doorposts and a door, a *bracha* is not recited unless all of these requirements have been met.

Affix Entrance/Basement Trap Door

According to halacha doorposts must be vertical. Thus, an opening in the floor or ceiling does not require a mezuzah.



Crawl Space Entrance

The minimum height for a room and doorway to require a mezuzah is 10 tefachim (approx. 33 inches). It must maintain that height for the minimum room size of 4 amos x 4 amos (approximately 6.25 feet x 6.25 feet [1.9 meters x 1.9 meters]⁵). A storage space is only obligated to have a mezuzah if it is accessed regularly (at least once a month). Because of these considerations, a crawl space does not usually require a mezuzah.



⁵ According to some opinions, a room of any dimension with an area of 39 square feet (3.62 square meters) requires a mezuzah. The Alter Rebbe is not of this opinion (366:5).

On Your Right Determining the Correct Doorpost for Mezuzah Placement

The Torah says, “וּכְתַבְתֶּם עַל מַזְוֹזוֹת בֵּיתְךָ,” and you shall write [and affix] them on the doorposts of your home. Chazal⁶ expounded upon the word “בֵּיתְךָ” as if it reads “בֵּיתְךָ,” your “way of entering.” Since most people begin walking with their right foot, the right doorpost—which is near the right foot—is considered the “way of entering.”⁷

⁶ Menachos 34a.

⁷ Following this teaching, it would seem that if all the members of a household are lefties, the mezuzah should be placed on the left, since for them that is the “way of entering.” (In this context, it wouldn’t matter if they were left-handed but left-footed, which can be measured by which foot they would use to kick.) However, *poskim* write that the mitzvah is not performed with the body and is not affected by the individual’s nature, and the “way of entering” follows the majority of people (*Rama* 289:2). The source of this halacha is in the *Mordechai* who writes that mezuzah is different “since it is meant to protect all the members of the house.” This would imply that if all (or even the majority) of the household members are left-footed, it would be placed on the left. The *Bach* expresses surprise at this, since we have never heard of anyone doing this (perhaps it is just so uncommon). He explains that it follows the majority of society

While the “right side” is obvious when entering the front door, it is less straightforward when it comes to doors within the home. In some scenarios, there is a logical definition for the “way of entering,” and it is clear that one enters *into* the room. In other scenarios, it is more difficult to determine which way is the “entrance” and which is the “exit.” One example is the doorway between a kitchen and dining room (when both have other entrances), which can be viewed either as an entrance to the kitchen or as an entrance to the dining room.⁸

Several rules are given to ascertain the status of a doorframe. According to minhag Chabad, they primarily depend

as a whole who are right-footed. The *Shach* explains the difference from tefilin which is performed with the body.

⁸ We do not require a mezuzah on both sides for each room, since the doorway is labeled as an **entrance** in one direction and an **exit** in the other direction, and only an **entrance** requires a mezuzah, not an exit (see *Rashi Menachos* 34a, DH Derech Biasecha).

on whether or not the doorframe has hinges.

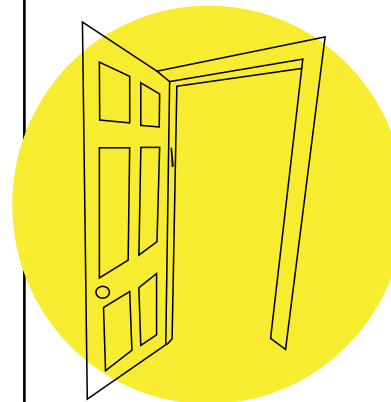
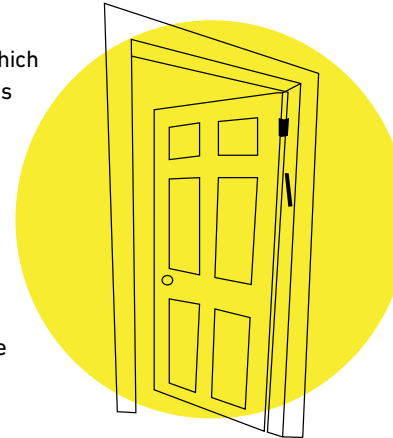
Doorframes With Hinged Doors

The correct location for mezuzah placement on doorframes with hinged doors is determined by a concept called *heker tzir* (recognition of the hinge). The room in which the hinge sits (and into which the door swings) is considered the inner room, and the doorway is considered an entrance to it.

We have a tradition from the Rebbe Rashab and earlier rebbeim⁹ (based on works of Rishonim) that *heker tzir* takes precedence over all the other considerations (For other doorways, see below, “Doorframes Without Hinges”).

⁹ In a letter to HaRav Yaakov Landau, rov in the home of the Rebbe Rashab and later in Bnei Brak, the Rebbe writes that he had heard that some ascribe this tradition to the Alter Rebbe. In his response, HaRav Landau writes that the Rebbe Rashab repeated it in the name of his father, the Rebbe Maharash, but did not mention a tradition from the Alter Rebbe (*Igros Kodesh*, Vol. 12, p. 436).

The room into which the door swings is considered the inner room, and the doorway is an entrance to it. The mezuzah is placed on the right doorpost (to the right of a person facing the room).



If the door of a room swings outward, the doorway is considered an entrance to the **outer** room,¹⁰ and the mezuzah is placed on the right side **exiting** the room.

It would seem that this is only true if there is another—even remotely—possible way to enter the room, such as a window or skylight which can open wide enough for a person to use as an entrance. If a secondary entrance exists, we can theoretically visualize the door to the room as an entrance to the outer hallway. If there is no such opening (or the window

¹⁰ Perhaps it can be said that other signs are circumstantial, whereas the place of the hinge is part of the house itself (particularly since the word from which we derive that it be placed on the right is “*beisecha*,” your house).

is gated with no accessible opening), we are forced to view the door as a door to the inner room,¹¹ and the mezuzah is placed on the right while entering. However, there are some who follow *heker tzir* in such a scenario as well.

¹¹ In a famous responsa, (printed in *Kovetz Razash*), Rav Zalman Shimon Dvorkin, rov of Crown Heights, records his memory of this rule as heard from Rebbe Rashab: “I remember when I was a youngster and I was a regular visitor in the home of the Rebbe [Rashab], there was a door where the mezuzah’s position caused all the rabbonim to wonder. I heard then that the Rebbe was asked and he replied that his father the Rebbe Maharash that even an inner room which has only one doorway and a window, and the door opens outward, that the mezuzah must be placed on the right side as one exits the room, in accordance with the *heker tzir*. The questioners then asked, ‘But it’s impossible to leave the room unless you have entered first, so the doorway is first an entrance and it should be placed on the right side when entering?’ The Rebbe replied, ‘One can enter through the window.’ The questioners probed further, ‘What if the window is high off the ground?’ And the Rebbe replied, ‘One can raise a ladder.’ “From this dialogue it is apparent that there must be another possible entrance. Rav Dvorkin presented this conclusion to the Rebbe, but the Rebbe did not address this point in his letter. (*Kfar Chabad*, Issue 743) Similarly, Rav Yaakov Landau records that the Rebbe Rashab mentioning “jumping through the window.” (While it was understood from the placement of a mezuzah in Rav Landau’s home that he followed *heker tzir* even when there was no window (Rabbi LY Raskin in *Nesivim Bidei Hashlichus*, Vol. 1 p. 90), the writer of these lines has since pointed out that if that room was less than the required size it would have the mezuzah on the left side for a different reason (the opinion of R. Akiva Eiger who requires a mezuzah coming out of a walk-in closet). Rabbi Raskin has acknowledged that this was indeed the situation there (*Haaros Ubiourim* 1058, p. 56).)



The front door of a home or a door leading from the house to the street or to an **unenclosed** outdoor area is considered an entrance to the home, not an entrance to the outdoors, regardless of the way the door swings, and the mezuzah is placed to the right entering the house.



If the door of a home swings out into an **enclosed** yard it is considered an entrance to the **yard**, which is required to have a mezuzah, and the mezuzah is placed to the right entering the yard.¹²

¹² See *Sefer HaMinhagim* p. 81; *Igros Kodesh*, Vol. 12, p. 424.

Doorframes Without Hinges

The correct placement of mezuzos on door frames without indicative hinges (i.e. doorframes without doors, sliding doors, pocket doors, or doors that swing both ways; see diagram below) is determined by the following three rules:

1) *Pnimi*: as mentioned, an inner room, i.e., a room with only one entrance.

2) *Rov Hilucho*: the direction of the traffic through that doorway upon entering the home from the street. Since, for example, the majority of traffic flow is from the hallway to the kitchen, we label the doorway as an entrance to the kitchen (though the kitchen has a lesser used back door).

3) *Rov Tashmisho*: the doorway is primarily an entrance to the main room. Some set the main room as the room more significant to basic living needs (i.e. eating and sleeping).

Others emphasize the room where more time is spent by the family members. A practical difference between these two is a doorway between a dining room and a living room. More time may be spent in the living room, however the dining room is used for more basic living.

If the first rule of *pnimi* applies (there is no other entrance into the room besides this doorframe) then the mezuzah is placed to the right when entering the room.

If another entrance into the room exists, there are differences of opinion on the order of rules 2 and 3 and a *rav* should be consulted.¹³

¹³ For example, if the flow of traffic is from the dining room into the kitchen, *rov hilucho* dictates that it be placed on the right into the kitchen, while *rov tashmisho* may lead to it being placed on the right entering the dining room where meals and other activities take place. The more accepted practice is to give preference to *rov hilucho* and to place it on the right in the direction that you normally enter. However, each person should consult their *rav* for a practical ruling.

Our Protectors

The Rebbe would often quote the words of the *Tur* (*Yoreh Deah* 285), "Whoever is careful with the mitzvah of mezuzah will see the lengthening of his days and the days of his children. Moreover, his home will be protected." The Rebbe would also add that not only does the mezuzah protect us while we are at home, but wherever we are.

Although we are generally discouraged from performing mitzvos for personal benefit, the protection of the mezuzah is not a segulah, but an inherent part of the mitzvah (see *Likutei Sichos*, Vol. 19, *Parshas Eikev* 5).

Ensuring Correct Placement

After writing about the halachos relevant for the kashrus of a mezuzah Rabbi Shalom Yosef Klein writes in his *Kol Sofrim* (addendum to *Keses HaSofer*, a classic guide for sofrim, Budapest 5683):

"Most importantly, one should not affix the mezuzos alone, but rather bring someone knowledgeable in these halachos to oversee the placement. For many, even talmidei chachomim, err in the placement of mezuzos.

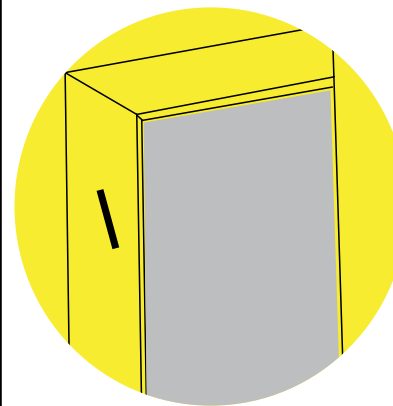
"Furthermore, if people hire experts to install and place furniture [appliances] correctly, then for the placement of a mezuzah, which entails many detailed and complex halachos, one should all the more so hire an expert for the proper placement."

➔ On the Doorposts of Your Home

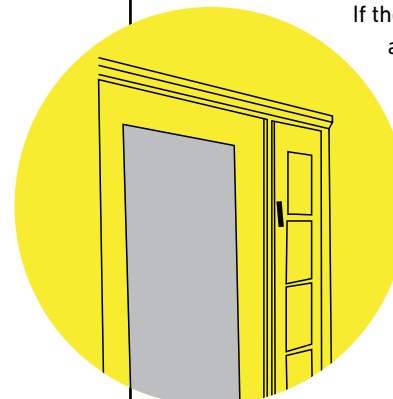
Determining the Correct Location on the Doorpost

The Torah tells us to affix the mezuzah "*al mezuzos beisecha*," on the doorpost of your home. The Gemara states that it belongs "*b'soch chalal hapesach*," within the cavity of the doorway. The Gemara then invalidates a mezuzah placed "*mei'achorei hapesach*," behind the doorway, and variant interpretations are put forth regarding what is considered "behind."

Ideally, a mezuzah should be placed within the doorframe ahead (on the outer side) of the door.

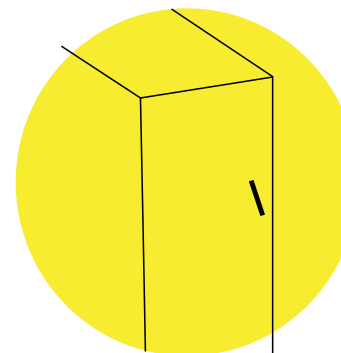


If there is no space to place the mezuzah within the doorframe ahead of the door, it can be placed in the doorframe after the door (on the inside of the room).



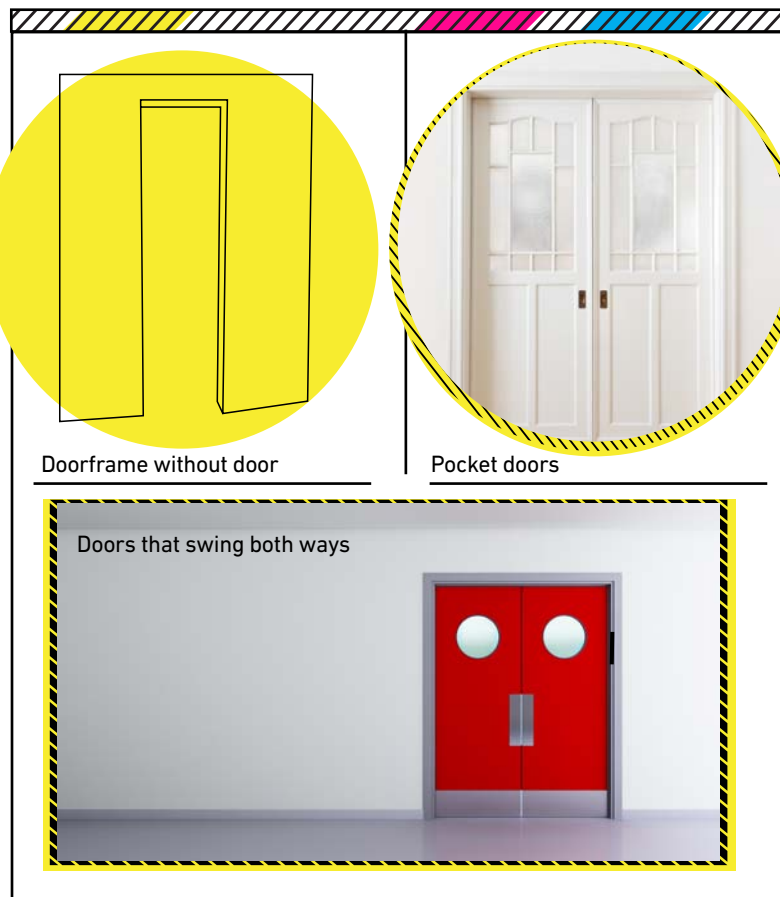
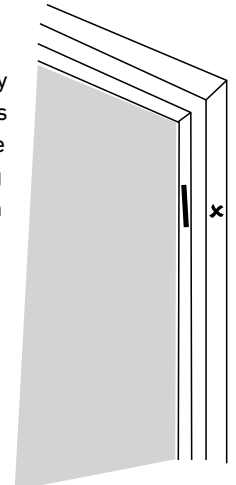
If there is no space in the doorframe either ahead or behind the door (i.e. the door fills the entire thickness of the frame when closed), ideally one should carve a cavity into the doorframe and place the mezuzah inside. If it is not possible to carve a space into the doorframe, the mezuzah should be placed on the outer face of the doorpost (facing the location from where one enters the room).

If there isn't any distinct doorpost, (e.g. a glass wall and door), the mezuzah should be placed on the wall to the right of the door outside of the room. It is essential that the mezuzah be placed **entirely** in the first tefach (approximately three inches) next to the doorway because further away is not considered part of the "doorpost" anymore, but the continuing wall.



Whenever possible, the mezuzah should be placed "*b'tefach hasomuch lachutz*," in the outermost handbreadth (about 3 inches) of the doorway.

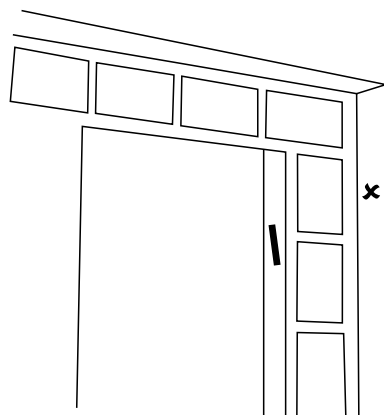
When a doorway has multiple layers of width, some prefer placing the mezuzah on the narrowest post (i.e. closest to where people walk) even if it won't be in the outermost tefach.



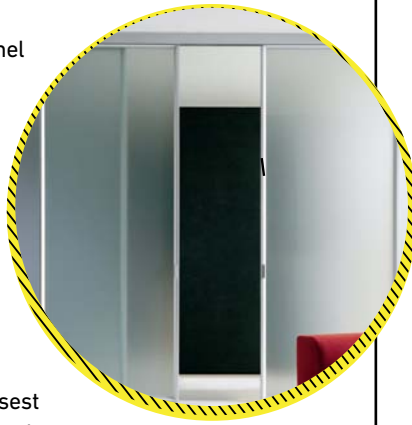
➔ Common Confusions

Doorway Styles that Often Lead to Misplacement of Mezuzos

The mezuzah must be placed on the doorpost, which is the post that is adjacent to the space which one can pass through. A sidelight is not part of the passageway and the mezuzah cannot be placed past it.

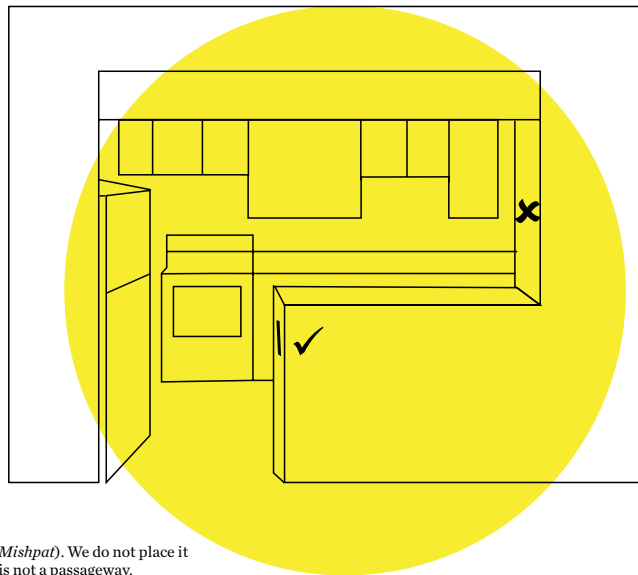


The stationary panel of a sliding door is not a door, but a glass wall. If the stationary panel is on the right side, the mezuzah should be placed at the **beginning** of the stationary panel which is closest to the passageway, since that is where the (glass) wall ends and the doorway begins.

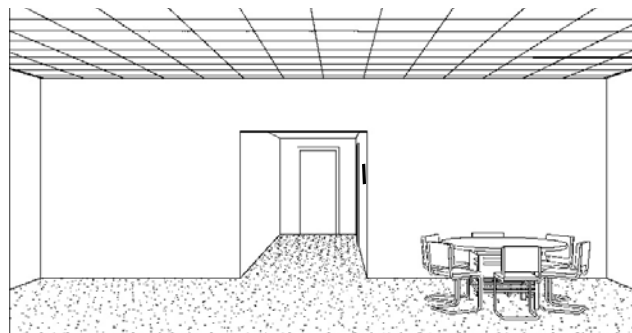


In order for a space to constitute a doorway it must have at least a right doorpost and a lintel, but it is not necessary that they be attached. As long as they are aligned they combine as a doorway based on the halachic concept of *gud asik*, that an object can be “stretched” upward.

In these examples of kitchen counter-bars on the right side of the entrance to a kitchen, the side of the counter is the doorpost with the lintel crossing directly above it. In such cases, the mezuzah is placed at the bottom of the top third of the counter (which is also the doorpost).¹⁴



¹⁴ *Derech HaChaim* (by the author of the *Chavas Daas* and *Nesivos HaMishpat*). We do not place it on the wall above the counter since that space (the top of the counter) is not a passageway.



The opinion of Rabbeinu Osher, the Rosh, is that the beginning of a wall, “*rosh kosel*,” also constitutes a doorpost. If the wall has no protruding right post but is envisioned as part of the doorframe, the doorway requires a mezuzah.

The rule of *rosh kosel* also applies when the side walls continue to run **perpendicular** to their original direction. Here too the edges of the side walls are considered doorposts.

Even a Frum Jew

In 5736 (1976), a plane traveling from Eretz Yisroel to Paris was hijacked by terrorists and brought to Entebbe, Uganda. All the Jews on board were held hostage to negotiate an exchange of terrorist prisoners in Eretz Yisroel. Through a miraculous rescue, almost all of them were saved.

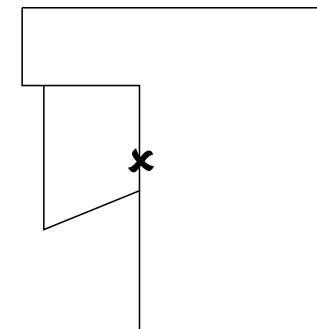
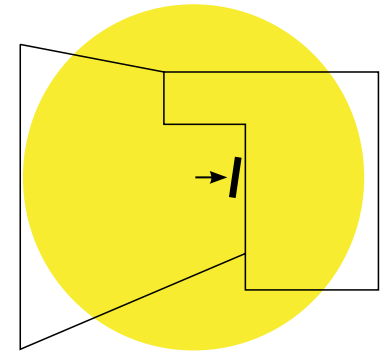
In a unique farbrengen dedicated to this incident, the Rebbe announced that it had been found that **every single one** of those that were held captive had mezuzos that were either invalid or positioned incorrectly!

The Rebbe related that among the hostages was a frum Jew who lives in New York. When Lubavitcher chassidim visited his home after his return and offered to check his mezuzos he declined at first, saying that his mezuzos were all according to *Shulchan Aruch*. However, the visitors did not let up, and they pleaded with him to let them come in and take a look, until he finally yielded. Once inside, they spotted a doorway which is obligated according to some, and yet it did not have a mezuzah. At this point, the man allowed them to check the rest of his home, and they discovered two doorways which were unquestionably obligated that did not have mezuzos!

The Rebbe concluded with an instruction that everyone should make sure that their own mezuzos are kosher and that they are placed correctly.

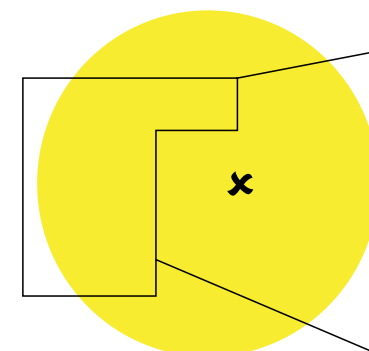
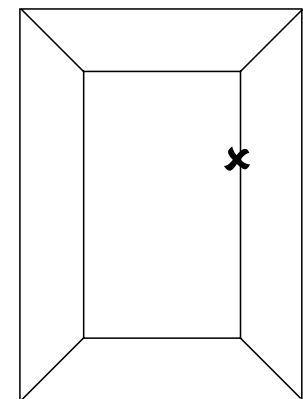
(*Sichos Kodesh* 5736, Vol. 2, p. 604)

Following the same rule of *rosh kosel*, if the wall bends on the **right**, but continues straight on the **left**, it requires a mezuzah (as long as there is a lintel above), since the primary doorpost is the right one.



The Rosh holds that only a right doorpost and a lintel are required to form a doorway. This is only the case if the left doorpost is formed by a wall. If there is no wall at all on the left side, a mezuzah is not required.

The rule of *rosh kosel* only applies to the **beginning** of a wall which forms the image of a doorpost. The end of a wall (i.e. when a hallway opens up into a wider room) is not considered a post when entering and does not require a mezuzah. It is therefore necessary to determine which side of the doorway would require a mezuzah.



If there is no post on the right side, the doorway is exempt.

An enclosed courtyard used for leisure or storage requires a *mezuzah*.



A doorway must consist of a minimum of a right doorpost and a lintel. An open layout in which the entrance between rooms does not have a descending lintel, is considered like one big room and the "doorways" do not require a mezuzah.



Posts which are installed for support or for décor are not considered doorposts and do not require a mezuzah.

If besides support or décor they also separate between areas, they do constitute a doorway and require a mezuzah.

An assessment is needed in each individual situation as to whether the posts serve a function of distinguishing two areas, and thus require a mezuzah, or if they are there just for other reasons, such as in the photo below:



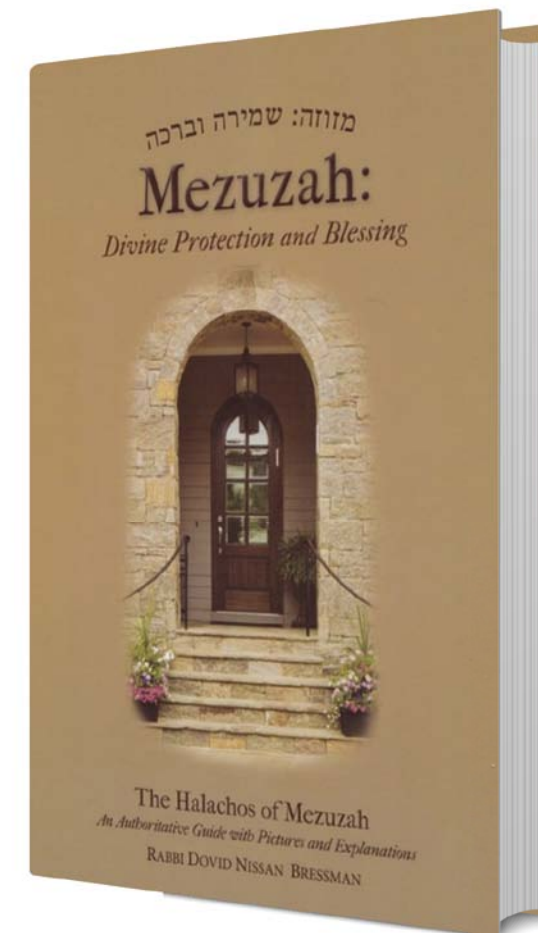
While we have tried to cover some of the more common scenarios, there are countless more questions that can arise when placing mezuzos. We hope that this article will bring the much needed awareness to the complexity of the matter, and efforts will be made to inquire and verify that mezuzos are placed properly—allowing for the most precise observance of the mitzvah and the greatest protection of the dwellers of the home.

To submit a question or to arrange a video-chat tour of your home or Chabad House, email rabbihellinger@machonstam.com. 

NOW IN STORES
IN ITS SECOND EDITION...

Mezuzah: *Divine Protection and Blessing*

PRACTICAL AND AUTHORITATIVE: FROM PURCHASING TO PLACING,
ALL YOU NEED TO KNOW ABOUT YOUR MEZUZOS, NOW IN ONE BOOK!



User friendly guide,
caters to all customs,
with emphasis on
Chabad practice.

Endorsed by Anash
Rabbonim worldwide.

Over 60 customized
professionally designed
illustrations.

Rabbi Gavriel Zinner (the Natei Gavriel) writes,

...Everything is organized with clear reasoning, in a simple language, and he [Rabbi Bressman] provides sources for every halacha. He also provides illustrations on all the commonly asked questions that are prevalent in our times in order to merit the public..."

Special Deal for Shluchim! Use code **COMPASS** at SeforimDeals.com/mezuzah and get 25% off!